D04 · Supplier Selection & Qualification

01 · RFI / RFP / RFQ design & execution

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1 WHAT IT IS

The RFI / RFP / RFQ family is the structured sourcing event toolkit — Request for Information (mapping the market), Request for Proposal (complex requirements with proposals), Request for Quotation (defined specifications with price competition). The discipline is choosing the right instrument for the situation and designing it so the responses are comparable, decision-grade, and free of the ambiguity that lets suppliers hide.

2 WHY IT MATTERS

The RFx is where supplier selection is won or lost — not at the award, but at the design of the event. **A poorly designed RFx produces responses that cannot be compared on equal footing**: different assumptions, different inclusions and exclusions, different baselines. The result is a procurement decision made on apparent price differences that are actually scope differences, with the cost surfacing months later as change orders. The standard reference works documents this clearly **(Monczka et al., 2020 — Purchasing and Supply Chain Management, 7th ed.)**: **RFx design is the procurement discipline that pays compounding returns** — every hour invested in clarifying the specification saves multiples in negotiation time, evaluation time, and post-award dispute. Sloppy RFx events are the leading indicator of a procurement organization that has not invested in its own craft.

3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Choose the right instrument — RFI to learn, RFP to propose, RFQ to price.** An RFI is the right tool when the market is not known and the buyer needs to map it; an RFP is right when the work is complex and the supplier's approach matters; an RFQ is right when the specification is locked and price is the variable. Using an RFQ for complex work is the most common mistake — it forces suppliers to bid blind, and they price the unknown as risk premium.
2. **Write the specification before the RFx — not as part of it.** The internal alignment on what is being bought must happen before the RFx is published. Specifications written under the time pressure of an active RFx event are specifications that suppliers will exploit. Separate the alignment from the sourcing.
3. **Structure the response template — do not let suppliers structure it for you.** A free-form proposal puts the buyer in the position of normalizing inconsistent responses; a structured response template (same line items, same pricing units, same terms) puts the supplier in the position of fitting their offer to your evaluation. The structure is the analytical leverage.
4. **Pre-define the evaluation criteria with weights — not after the responses arrive.** Evaluation criteria defined after the responses are evaluation criteria that fit a preferred outcome. The weights, the scoring rubric, the must-meet vs. nice-to-have requirements — all must be locked before the RFx is published, ideally signed off by the cross-functional evaluation committee.
5. **Run a clarification window — not a one-way submission.** Suppliers will have legitimate questions; if they cannot ask them, they answer with assumptions. A structured Q&A window with publication of all answers to all bidders prevents informational asymmetry between suppliers and produces cleaner responses.
6. **Score systematically — and document the rationale for every decision.** The evaluation must be repeatable: another evaluator with the same criteria and the same responses should reach the same conclusions. The documentation is what protects the decision from post-award challenge and what builds institutional learning for the next RFx.

WORKED EXAMPLE — ILLUSTRATIVE

A medical device manufacturer runs an RFP for a sterile packaging category — **$12.8M annual spend, 4 suppliers invited, complex regulatory requirements (FDA-cleared, ISO 13485)**. The previous procurement attempt (3 years earlier) was an RFQ that produced quotes ranging from $X to $1.6X, of which 70% was eventually adjusted post-award as the suppliers discovered scope they had not priced. The new RFP is structured with: (1) detailed specifications written and reviewed by R&D, quality, and operations over 6 weeks before publication; (2) structured response template with 14 line items, fixed pricing units, and a separate technical narrative; (3) weighted evaluation criteria (technical 40%, commercial 35%, supplier capability 25%) signed off by the evaluation committee before publication; (4) a 2-week clarification window with 47 questions answered to all 4 suppliers simultaneously; (5) structured scoring by 5 evaluators with documented rationale. Result: **final responses comparable across all 14 line items, decision made in 4 weeks vs. previous 14 weeks, post-award change orders down 78% in the first contract year, $2.1M of identified hidden cost surfaced in the RFP itself rather than emerging later**.

IN PRACTICE

Choose the right instrument for the situation

RFI when the market is unknown and the question is who can do this; RFP when requirements are complex and the answer involves proposed solutions; RFQ when specs are defined and the answer is price. Issuing an RFQ where you needed an RFP guarantees comparable prices on the wrong solution; the instrument choice is the most consequential decision in the event.

Write the specification before launching

Every ambiguous spec is a free option the supplier exercises in their favor. Lock the spec before the event opens — units of measure, tolerances, test methods, acceptance criteria, packaging, delivery terms — because the supplier's interpretation of an ambiguous clause is always the cheaper one to quote and the more expensive one to receive.

Pre-define evaluation criteria with weights

Decide the scoring rubric and its weights before responses arrive, not after. Criteria defined post-hoc always converge on the supplier the team already preferred — the weights become the rationalization, not the decision. Pre-committed weights are the only way the event produces a defensible award rather than a justified one.

Run a structured clarification window

Publish all clarifications to all bidders simultaneously, in writing, within a defined window. Bilateral clarifications outside the window destroy comparability and create implicit pricing of information asymmetry. The discipline is unglamorous and a few suppliers will resist it — and it is the single most underrated lever for keeping the event honest.

WHAT YOU WOULD USE

RFX / E-SOURCING PLATFORMS

SAP Ariba Sourcing / Coupa Sourcing / Jaggaer — Enterprise e-sourcing platforms with templated RFx workflows, scoring engines, and clarification management — the default when the operation is already on a procurement suite **(SAP — vendor; Coupa — vendor; Jaggaer — vendor)**.

Scanmarket, Keelvar, Bonfire — Specialized sourcing platforms with advanced features (auction formats, bid optimization, structured Q&A) — strong for operations running frequent sourcing events without the full procurement suite footprint **(Scanmarket — vendor; Keelvar — vendor)**.

ProcureWare, RFP360, Loopio — RFP-focused platforms with response library management, evaluation workflows, and collaborative scoring — strong for complex RFPs with many stakeholders and many bidders **(Loopio — vendor)**.

Structured Excel + email + SharePoint — For operations not at scale — a well-designed Excel response template plus a structured Q&A process via email or SharePoint works fine, provided the discipline of design is in place. Tooling does not create good RFx events; rigor does.

4 SO WHAT

The RFx that does not control the question hands the supplier the answer. Choose the right instrument for the situation, write specifications before the event, structure the response template, pre-define evaluation criteria with weights, run a structured clarification window, and score systematically with documented rationale. The plants that invest in RFx craft buy back the leverage that comes from comparable responses; the plants that do not pay the structural premium hidden inside incomparable bids.